

AVIATOR (1932–2015)

FRANK E. PETERSEN

When Frank Petersen graduated from the Naval Aviation Cadet Program in 1952, he became the Marine Corps' first Black American aviator. Petersen served in the Korean War and the Vietnam War, making some 350 sorties over the course of the two conflicts. In Vietnam, where he flew a McDonnell Douglas F-4 Phantom, he was forced to bail out when his aircraft was shot down on a 1968 mission. He survived, and that same year became the first Black American to command the Black Knights squadron. In 1979, he was made the first Black general in the Marine Corps.



» AFTER

The US Marines continue to be a vital part of American military action overseas.

INTO THE 1980s

By the end of the war, US strategic interest had begun to shift to the Middle East. Thirteen Marines were among 65 Americans taken captive when Iranian revolutionaries stormed the **US Embassy in Tehran** in 1979.

In 1983, 220 Marines were killed by a car bomb during an intervention in **Lebanon**. Later that year, Marines took part in the US invasion of **Grenada**.

IRAQ AND AFGHANISTAN

Marine aerial and ground units led the invasion of Iraq during the **First Gulf War** (1991) and were called upon again during the **Iraq War** (2003–11) that toppled Saddam Hussein, and the **War in Afghanistan** (2001–21). A small number of Marines continue to perform advise-and-assist missions in Iraq.